

OP1 Ambition Roadmap

Pillar	Opportunity	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	Individual or 4-10 team
Mode	1:1 (manager-employee) or team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (foundation exercise)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of personalised development plans, unclear career aspirations, succession planning gaps, leadership development needs, low opportunity scores

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Seeing a credible path forward activates serotonin (the chemical behind purpose and status confidence) and dopamine (anticipation of achievement). When employees can visualise their own growth trajectory, the brain treats it as a goal with a progress path, which sustains motivation over months and years rather than just during a good week.

The absence of a visible path does the opposite. When people cannot see how their current work connects to their future, the brain defaults to survival mode: do the minimum, avoid risk, keep options open. This looks like disengagement but is actually the brain's rational response to an unclear future. The Ambition Roadmap makes the path visible, which makes commitment neurologically rational.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"Most people have a vague sense of what they want from their career but have never mapped it specifically. This exercise turns 'I'd like to grow' into 'here's exactly what I'm aiming for, what I need to get there, and what my next step is.' The clearer the picture, the more motivated we are to work toward it."

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Honest Aspiration Question (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm going to ask you a question that sounds simple but most people find surprisingly difficult: Where do you want to be in 2-3 years? Not where you think you should be. Not what you think I want to hear. Where do you genuinely want to be? It's okay if the answer isn't in this company. It's okay if you don't

know. Start with what you know."

Give 5 minutes for individual reflection and writing. In a 1:1 setting, let the employee talk through their thinking. In a team setting, this stays private.

FACILITATION NOTE

Many people answer with what they think they should want ("I want to be a manager") rather than what they actually want. Watch for hedging language: "I suppose I should be aiming for...", "Everyone says the next step is...". Gently challenge: "That's one path. Is it YOUR path? If you could design the next 2 years without any constraints, what would it look like?"

Phase 2: The Roadmap Build (15 minutes)

Each person creates a simple three-column roadmap:

Where I Am Now	What I Need to Get There	Where I Want to Be (2-3 years)
Current role, skills, experience What I'm good at What energises me vs. what drains me	Skills to develop (link to L1) Experiences I need (projects, exposure, relationships) Support I need (mentoring, training, stretch assignments) Barriers to address	Specific role or type of work What success looks and feels like What I want to be known for

The middle column is where the real work happens. "Skills to develop" connects directly to L1 (Skills Diagnostic). "Experiences I need" connects to OP14 (Stretch Assignments). "Support I need" connects to OP4 (Mentorship).

Phase 3: The Next Step (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"The roadmap shows the big picture. Now make it real. What is the single most important next step you can take in the next 30 days to move along this roadmap? Not five things. One thing. Something specific, achievable, and within your control."

In a 1:1 setting, the manager commits to one specific support action: "I'll connect you with [person]", "I'll look for a stretch assignment in [area]", "I'll schedule time for us to review your progress in 6 weeks."

In a team setting, each person shares their next step (but not their full roadmap, which stays private unless they choose to share).

Phase 4: The Review Schedule (5 minutes)

Schedule a roadmap review: quarterly works for most people. The roadmap is a living document, not a one-time exercise. Aspirations change, opportunities emerge, barriers shift. Without scheduled reviews, the roadmap gathers dust.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Someone says "I don't know where I want to be"	This is honest and common. "Not knowing is a valid starting point. Let me ask it differently: what kind of work do you find most energising? What do you want to do more of and less of? Sometimes the direction becomes clear from the preferences rather than from a specific destination."
Someone's aspiration is outside the current organisation	Do not react negatively. "I appreciate you being honest about that. My job is to support your development whether that keeps you here or prepares you for what's next. What can we do in the next year that serves both your growth and the team's needs?" This is counterintuitive, but managers who support external aspirations build more loyalty than those who penalise honesty.
The roadmap reveals that the manager has no relevant opportunities to offer	Be transparent: "I'm limited in what I can offer within our team right now. Let's look broader: are there cross-functional projects, secondments, or mentoring relationships outside our team that could fill the gap?" Connect to OP3 (Internal Mobility) and OP4 (Mentorship).

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Aspirations feel genuine, not performative The middle column produces specific, actionable items The next step is concrete and bounded
Within 4-8 weeks	The employee has taken their next step The manager has delivered on their support commitment The roadmap is referenced in subsequent 1:1 conversations
CLOVER ERA data (6-8 weeks)	Opportunity scores increase Qualitative data references career direction, growth, or future Retention indicators may improve (visible paths reduce flight risk)
Red flags	If roadmaps are created but never reviewed, the exercise built hope without follow-through. This is worse than not doing the exercise at all. Schedule the review before ending the session.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
OP6: Career Path Transparency	OP1 maps individual aspirations; OP6 maps what the organisation offers. Together they show the match/gap.	Complementary
L1: Skills Diagnostic	OP1's 'skills to develop' column connects directly to L1's priority gaps.	Run L1 alongside OP1
OP4: Mentorship	OP1 often identifies mentorship as a support need. OP4 provides the structure.	OP1 feeds into OP4
OP14: Stretch Assignments	OP1's 'experiences I need' column identifies stretch assignment targets.	OP1 feeds into OP14